



Your labor is done: you have your newborn **baby in your arms**, and you are ready to get to know this tiny new person, and to start your life as a family. The doctor has a **few more checks** to make, and this **care you receive** immediately after the birth is sometimes referred to as the fourth stage of labor.

Right after birth

Your baby's first moments

Just after your baby is born, and provided all is well, the doctor will place him on your chest to enjoy a first embrace. Your baby will be rubbed and patted dry and have a clean towel placed over him while you hold him skin to skin. Meanwhile, the cord will be clamped and cut by the doctor, or by your partner if so planned.

Your baby will be given an initial checkup (see pp.238–39), which may be done while you are holding him, then he may be weighed. Whether at home or in a hospital or birthing center, your doctor will try to do the necessary checkup as unobtrusively as possible, so as not to interfere with these first moments when you and your partner begin bonding with your baby. If you or your baby needs medical attention after the birth, the medical team will try to reunite you as soon as they can.

If you have decided to breast-feed it is important to offer this to your baby within the first hour. Your nurse will help you to get your baby to latch on. His sucking and rooting reflexes (see p.267) are strong at this time.

Taking care of you

Before you leave the delivery room, or before your doctor leaves you if you're at home, she or he will check that

your body is beginning to show signs of recovery from the birth. Your nurse will take your blood pressure and temperature, feel your belly to make sure your uterus has begun to contract, assess your blood loss, and examine your placenta and membranes to ensure they are complete. Your doctor will also ask to assess your perineum to check for any injury—primarily this means checking whether or not you suffered a tear as your baby was born, and if so whether or not this needs stitches.

Your doctor will explain what he or she is doing as the checkup is being done, and you should be able to continue to hold your baby while you're given the once-over. In fact, your baby can provide the perfect distraction from this final stage in the delivery room.

Your emotions right after birth

Unsurprisingly, you're likely to feel emotional when you've given birth: not only do you have raised hormone levels, but also the relief and excitement of meeting your baby can be overwhelming. Don't worry if you feel like crying—doctors and nurses are used to all kinds of emotions in the delivery room and will offer support, encouragement, reassurance, or quietude as your mood dictates.